

TIPP — Crisis Survival Skills

Greater Nashua Mental Health Center

Instructions: TIPP is a DBT crisis-survival skill for rapidly lowering extreme emotional arousal when you are in crisis and cannot think clearly. Use it for short-term distress, then follow up with other coping skills. Check with a clinician before cold-water or intense exercise if you have a heart condition or eating disorder.

T — Temperature

Change your body temperature with cold water to activate the dive reflex and slow your heart rate. Hold your breath and put your face in cold water (or a cold pack over your eyes/cheeks) for 30 seconds.

My plan for cold temperature change:

I — Intense Exercise

Engage in brief, intense aerobic exercise (even 5–10 minutes) to expend the body's stored physical energy that accompanies strong emotion — jumping jacks, fast walking, running in place.

Intense exercise I can do right now:

P — Paced Breathing

Slow your breathing to about 5–6 breaths per minute. Make your exhale longer than your inhale (e.g., breathe in for 4, out for 6) to engage the parasympathetic nervous system.

Distress BEFORE paced breathing (0 = calm, 10 = crisis):



Distress AFTER paced breathing:



P — Paired Muscle Relaxation

While breathing out, tense a muscle group, notice the tension, then release and notice the difference. Work through the body — hands, arms, shoulders, face, legs.

Which TIPP skill helped most, and when will I use it next?